Harsha Vemulapalli

Design & Research Executive | Enterprise SaaS & Platforms

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SUMMARY

Design and research executive with 25+ years of experience and 16+ years leading multi-disciplinary organizations spanning product design, user research, design systems, content strategy, and localization. Grew Siemens' global experience organization from 5 to 70 people across seven countries as a manager of managers, and led design through enterprise transformations at Siemens, VMware, and Bosch. AI-forward leader who sets org-wide AI strategy, from research agents and AI-driven localization to AI-assisted prototyping that ships to production, and pairs adoption with evaluation standards that protect research rigor. Holds the quality bar on accessibility and craft across enterprise SaaS, marketplace, and global multi-language platforms.

SELECTED IMPACT

- Led experience design for Siemens Xcelerator Marketplace, a **€9.4B digital sales channel that grew 19%** in FY2025.
- Built and scaled design organizations of **70 (Siemens), 75 (VMware), ~120 (Bosch), and 140 (GM)**; grew **10+ designers into manager and director roles**.
- Own a **$2M annual operating budget** (excluding salaries) and report to the SVP of eCommerce; partner as a peer with VP and SVP business leaders on Xcelerator Marketplace growth, and with Product and Engineering on roadmap and tradeoffs.

SKILLS

Organization Leadership: Manager of managers · Org design & scaling · Career paths & development programs · Remote, globally distributed teams · Psychological safety · Executive influence with Product & Engineering

AI Strategy & Adoption: Org-wide AI strategy · AI-assisted research synthesis · LLM evaluation & hallucination guardrails · Agentic workflows · Conversational UX · AI-assisted SDLC (Figma Make, Claude Code, React prototyping)

Research & Content: Research methodologies & ResearchOps · Insight-led product strategy · A/B testing & experimentation · Content strategy · Globalization & localization · AI-assisted translation

Quality & Systems: Design system governance & adoption · Accessibility (WCAG 2.1) · Design critique & review · Workflow automation for design & content compliance · Experience metrics & scorecards

EXPERIENCE

Global Director, Experience Design & Research — Jan 2025 – Present

Siemens Digital Industries Software · Detroit, MI

Lead the global UX, research, content strategy, and localization organization, grown from 5 to 70 people (about 58 employees plus embedded contractors) across seven countries — supporting a complex B2B software ecosystem and AI-driven customer experiences.

- Set the org's AI agenda: led a Microsoft Copilot research agent over a unified research repository (**–34% time-to-insight, +20% data utilization**) and a persona agent grounded in 80 interviews and 800+ surveys, now in daily use by research and approved for the extended design team, with accuracy and hallucination evaluation gating wider rollout.
- Consolidated **150+ sites into one Siemens.com**, rebuilt around the marketplace — unifying the marketing site, first- and third-party marketplaces, and business-unit selling channels into a single explorable catalog of hundreds of thousands of products — and govern the One Siemens design system serving 3,000+ creators across **100K+ pages**.
- Own localization, translation, and currency across **38 regions and 32 languages**, where regions can carry multiple languages and currencies; use AI tools to tailor content to each market.
- Hold the quality bar at scale: no UI moves to development without an accessibility review, and built **workflow automation** that validates design-system compliance in design and brand, accessibility (WCAG 2.1), and content-strategy compliance in content authoring.
- Led the Xcelerator Marketplace experience from go-live, partnering as a peer with VP and SVP business leaders on its growth; built third-party page templates that made the marketplace a home for partner products and services.
- Own the design of the purchase and finance funnel experience, partnering closely with Product and Engineering to ship platform-level improvements at enterprise scale.

- Grew **10+ designers** into manager and director roles; built a career growth tool that combines industry best-practice frameworks with self- and manager-scoring, so team members at every level can find and develop the skills for the roles they aspire to.

Director of User Experience, Digital Industries Software Apr 2023 – Jan 2025
Siemens Digital Industries Software · Detroit, MI

- Player/coach on an AI-powered product finder: cut scope to the customer's next step, drew the initial layout, validated with 5-second and data-driven tests, prototyped in Figma Make, and shipped in React on Contentful; **clicks-to-content cut from 77 to 4, +23% conversion, and +28% engagement**, measured in Amplitude.

Senior Manager, UX Design, Amazon Smart Vehicles Sep 2022 – Jan 2023
Amazon · 13-person team

- Directed design and research for a multi-stakeholder vehicle platform with embedded commerce, media, and advertising; introduced leaner processes that cut timelines 12%.

Senior Director, User Experience Design & Research Apr 2021 – Sep 2022
VMware · 75-person team

Led design, research, and experience strategy through VMware's Sub-to-SaaS transformation — a company-level inflection point — while redesigning tools and services for a post-COVID hybrid workforce.

- Redesigned mission-critical CPQ quoting workflows for **35,000+ users, cutting time-on-task 30%** and accelerating SaaS deal velocity.
- Shipped an experience scorecard used by thousands of employees; re-platformed hybrid-work systems while holding **75% + CSAT and reducing support load 20%**.
- Operated as player/coach: contributed directly to critical design work while mentoring senior ICs and scaling leadership capacity across a distributed team.

Director, Digital Brand, UX and Research Oct 2019 – Apr 2021
CARFAX · 30-person team

- Led UX, graphic design, and research teams through an end-to-end product redesign, achieving a **7% conversion lift** and a **26% reduction in dev churn**.
- Established a repeatable design process and research cadence that improved brand consistency and customer retention.

Head of Design, North America Oct 2016 – Oct 2019
Robert Bosch, LLC · grew from 0 to ~120

Joined as employee 0 and built Bosch's internal design consultancy from the ground up into a ~120-person practice (5 direct reports, 90 indirect).

- Drove service design initiatives that **saved $6M**; led research and design for an AI/ML infotainment system that lowered hardware costs and glance times.

User Experience Manager Sep 2014 – Oct 2016
General Motors · team scaled to 140

- Built a pattern-driven global strategy that launched **7 mobile apps in 23 languages** within one year across seven brands.
- Created an in-app services revenue stream exceeding **$1M in its first year**.

Earlier: Design Manager, Air Mobility Command (U.S. Air Force) · UX & Analytics Manager, CDC (70M+ page views a year) · Interaction Designer, Blackbaud · Product Manager & Design Engineer, Morris Digitalworks

EDUCATION, CERTIFICATIONS & SPEAKING

B.S., Information Technology, American InterContinental University

Certifications: Decision by Design (Farnam Street) · Google AI Essentials · Behavioral Design (Irrational Labs) · UX Research (University of Denver) · Certified Scrum Product Owner & ScrumMaster

Speaking & research: "Leading Teams through AI" panel, Research Guild (2025) · Forrester: Leveraging AI for B2B E-commerce (2025) · IDC MarketScape, Digital B2B Ecosystems (2025) · Automotive Cockpit HMI (2018) · AV18 (2018)